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Article *in* Journal of Applied Psychology · October 2023

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The Role of Self-Interest in Unethical Pro-Organizational Behavior:

A Nomological Network Meta-Analysis

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We have no conflicts of interest to disclose. We would like to thank Paul Spector and Oliver Sheldon for providing feedback on an earlier draft of this paper. We would also like to thank the faculty and students in Indiana University's Department of Management and Entrepreneurship who provided construct ratings. Correspondence concerning this article should be addressed to Logan M. Steele at 4202 E. Fowler Ave, Tampa, FL 33620. Email: lmsteele@usf.edu.

Accepted for publication at *Journal of Applied Psychology*

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Abstract

To date, the unethical pro-organizational behavior (UPB) literature has been guided by a prosocial perspective, which argues that people engage in UPB primarily to benefit the employers with whom they identify and have a positive social exchange. According to this perspective, employees who are characteristically self-interested are less likely to engage in UPB. However, recent evidence suggests self-interest may play a larger role in motivating UPB than originally theorized. To clarify this controversy, we offer two different, but not necessarily mutually exclusive, perspectives of UPB—one in which UPB is driven primarily by prosocial motives and one in which it is driven primarily by self-interest. We tested which of these accounts of UPB was more strongly supported by comparing UPB's relationships with two nomological networks: one containing relatively prosocially-motivated constructs and the other containing relatively self-interest-motivated constructs. Two of the eight hypotheses from the prosocial perspective were supported, while seven of the eight hypotheses from the self-interest perspective were supported. Additionally, the average absolute value of UPB's correlations with prosocial perspective constructs was .09, while the comparable average correlation with self-interest perspective constructs was .33. Thus, the results favored the self-interest perspective. We discuss how these findings change our theoretical understanding of UPB by acknowledging both its prosocial and self-interest motivations, and we accordingly propose a revised definition for UPB that allows for both of these motivations. We also examined more broadly the relationship between UPB and other constructs to provide a comprehensive meta-analytic overview of this literature.

Keywords: unethical pro-organizational behavior, meta-analysis, nomological network

The Role of Self-Interest in Unethical Pro-Organizational Behavior: A Nomological Network Meta-Analysis

Defrauding customers, stealing from competitors, concealing damaging information from the public—the news is replete with examples like these where employees use unethical means to benefit their organizations. Although unethical behavior in the workplace has been studied for decades, only much more recently has this research included unethical behaviors done with the intent of benefiting the organization. Umphress and colleagues referred to these behaviors as *unethical pro-organizational behaviors* (UPB), developing a theory and measure of UPB about a decade ago (Umphress et al., 2010; Umphress & Bingham, 2011).

Since the inaugural theoretical and empirical work, research examining UPB has grown considerably and spanned multiple disciplines including industrial–organizational psychology, management, social psychology, accounting, and marketing. In the ten or so years since the inception of UPB, scholars have already conducted nearly 140 quantitative studies and explored dozens of possible antecedents, correlates, and consequences. These studies have largely focused on testing relationships specified in Umphress and Bingham's (2011) theory; however, more recent research has begun to creatively expand this original work (e.g., Bonner et al., 2017; Umphress et al., 2020). As a result, there is a need to summarize this literature, take an account of which aspects of the theory have been supported, which aspects may warrant revision, and identify the opportunities for future research. In the present study, we build on recent qualitative reviews of the UPB literature (Mishra et al., 2022; Mo et al., 2022) by reviewing more studies and providing a meta-analytic review of the UPB literature to date. In addition to giving insight into the nomological network of UPB, this comprehensive summary of relationships also allowed us to test an important theoretical tension in the UPB literature.

Critical to Umphress and Bingham's (2011) theory of UPB is the idea that UPB is driven by both a sense of obligation, due to positive social exchange between employees and their employers, and as a means to support an organization with which they strongly identity. But prosocial behaviors are not always performed with purely prosocial motives (Bolino, 1999), which leads one to wonder, what is the role of self-interest in UPB? To date, the answer to that question has been unclear. Umphress and Bingham (2011) argue that unethical behaviors that benefit the organization but which are performed "with the intention of benefiting the self alone … would *not* be considered unethical pro-organizational behavior" (p. 623, emphasis added). They also argue that individuals who characteristically are more driven by self-interest are *less* likely to engage in UPB (p. 630). However, recent studies suggest that self-interest may play a larger role in UPB than originally theorized (e.g., Lee et al., 2019; Mishra et al., 2022; Naseer et al., 2020). Thus, in the present study, we shed light on this controversy by going beyond single studies and integrating the entire body of evidence to date. Specifically, we test two different, but not necessarily mutually exclusive, explanations of what motivates UPB by comparing the strength of relationships between UPB and two sets of nomological networks—one associated with being motivated by positive social exchange and social identity (i.e., the prosocial perspective) and the other associated with being motivated by self-interest (i.e., the self-interest perspective).

In quantitatively synthesizing the UPB literature and exploring the theoretical tension highlighted above, this study makes the following contributions. First, we advance the theory of UPB by resolving competing views concerning the role of self-interest. We show how propositions about the antecedents to UPB in the prosocial perspective (Umphress & Bingham, 2011) must be reevaluated in light of the evidence collected over the past decade. Pruning extant

theory enables UPB scholars to develop a more parsimonious understanding of this important construct (Leavitt et al., 2010). Second, by focusing on the role of self-interest, we provide a foundation for future research to consider a broader set of antecedents to UPB (e.g., dark personality traits; Moshagen et al., 2018) than was originally theorized. Finally, consistent with the evidence we observe, we offer a revised definition of UPB to help inform future research.

Theoretical Background

The construct of UPB was introduced by Umphress and colleagues in a theoretical paper (Umphress & Bingham, 2011) and scale development paper (Umphress et al., 2010) a little more than a decade ago. These scholars observed that employees at times act unethically on behalf of the organization, but we lacked a construct label for these behaviors and a theoretical account for them. Umphress and Bingham (2011) defined UPB as "actions that are intended to promote the effective functioning of the organization or its members (e.g., leaders) and violate core societal values, mores, laws, or standards of proper conduct" (p. 622). In addition, they argued that there are two key antecedents to UPB: positive social exchange (Blau, 1964; Cropanzano & Mitchell, 2005) and organizational identity (Ashforth & Mael, 1989; Tajfel & Turner, 1986). For the first antecedent, they argue that employees engage in UPB to reciprocate positive social exchange with their employers. In other words, employees perceive lying to customers or selling faulty products as a means to repay their organizations for favorable treatment and support. For the second antecedent, Umphress and Bingham (2011) argue that employees engage in UPB when they strongly identify with their organizations in order to advance their organizations' (i.e., their in-groups') interests. Employees with a strong organizational identity see UPB as "dutiful acts" that serve their organization. Taken together, Umphress and Bingham's (2011) theoretical

account of UPB paints a picture of a "good citizen" (p. 626) prosocially fulfilling their sense of duty to the organization.

While the behaviors encompassed by the UPB construct may benefit the organization, this might not be the sole or even primary intent motivating this behavior. Employees engage in behaviors that benefit the organization (e.g., organizational citizenship behaviors) for a variety of reasons, including those that advance their own interests, such as earning a promotion or improving one's reputation (Bolino, 1999; Bolino et al., 2016). Thus, it is possible that the same applies to UPB. Indeed, Umphress and Bingham (2011) acknowledged that self-interest may play a role in motivating UPB; however, they argue that being characteristically driven by self-interest makes it *less* likely, not more, that an employee will engage in UPB. They theorize that highly self-interested employees are less likely to be concerned with the welfare of their organization and less likely to respond to positive social exchange relationships. If these individuals do engage in unethical behavior, the motivation for it is dominated by self-interest, which, by definition, would not be considered UPB.

Nevertheless, recent studies have shown that constructs associated with pursuing self-interest (e.g., entitlement, Machiavellianism, perceptions of organizational politics) have a positive relationship with UPB (e.g., Castille et al., 2018; A. Lee et al., 2019; Valle et al., 2019). Why might this be the case? We argue that behaviors encompassed by the UPB construct often benefit oneself as much as they benefit the organization. For example, when an employee uses deception to make a sale, not only does the organization earn revenue, but the employee may also earn extra commission or other rewards. Similarly, sabotaging a competing restaurant by posting fake reviews may increase the customer flow to one's own restaurant, which is a boon to one's job security and may earn favor from one's supervisor. Even well-intentioned pay-for-

performance plans could create conditions that would incentivize employees to engage in UPB at least in part out of self-interest. A well-known example is Sears setting challenging sales goals for its commission-paid auto repair employees in the early 1990s, which incentivized those employees to do unnecessary repairs and overcharge for their work (Ordóñez et al., 2009). Therefore, individuals who are characteristically more self-interested have just as much reason to engage in UPB as those who are more concerned about the welfare of an organization with which they identify or about reciprocating positive social exchanges. It is clear that multiple motives may influence UPB, but questions remain about whether the effect of self-interest is robust enough to warrant revision of Umphress and Bingham's (2011) theory about the relative magnitude of these two motives.

Next, we propose two sets of hypotheses to determine which of these motives—that is, prosocial or self-interest—is more strongly related to UPB. The logic of these hypotheses is based on the concepts of convergent and discriminant validity. That is, one way to shed light on the nature of a construct (e.g., UPB) is to examine its relationships with other constructs—namely, its nomological network. If UPB is driven more strongly by prosocial motives, then UPB should correlate more strongly with other constructs that share a similar motivational basis (convergent validity) and less strongly with constructs that do not (discriminant validity). Similarly, if UPB is more strongly driven by self-interest, then it should correlate more strongly with other constructs that share similar self-interested motives. Consistent with Umphress and Bingham's (2011) original theory, for the prosocial perspective of UPB, we draw on social exchange theory (Blau, 1964; Cropanzano & Mitchell, 2005) and social identity theory (Tajfel & Turner, 1986) to hypothesize that constructs associated with feeling or acting out of a sense of duty and loyalty should be positively related to UPB. For the self-interest perspective of UPB,

based on behavioral decision theory (Edwards, 1961; Loewenstein, 1996; Shafir & LeBoeuf, 2002), we start with the premise that because self-interest plays an important role in influencing human behavior generally, self-interest also motivates UPB. Thus, we hypothesize that constructs associated with wanting to advance, or actually advancing, one's interests, even at a cost to others, should be positively related to UPB.

In the Appendix, we explain how the two sets of constructs were assigned to either the prosocial or self-interest perspective. The Appendix also contains sensitivity analyses which examined alternative construct categorization schemes.

The Prosocial Perspective

As described above, Umphress and Bingham (2011) made the case that there are two key antecedents to UPB: positive social exchange and organizational identity. These antecedents form the motivational basis for the prosocial perspective. That is, employees engage in UPB out of a sense of duty to reciprocate when they have a positive social exchange relationship with their employer and/or as a way to advance the interests of the organization with which they strongly identify. Thus, the prosocial perspective suggests that UPB should be related to other constructs that share these positive social exchange or organizational identity motives. Of the many constructs in UPB's nomological network, a handful most clearly tap into similar motivational bases: namely, certain attitudes about and perceptions of the workplace (i.e., organizational commitment, organizational justice, job satisfaction, group identity, organizational identity, and value alignment), the relationship with one's supervisor (i.e., leader–member exchange), and organizational citizenship behavior. We do not make the case that these are the only constructs in UPB's nomological network that might share these motives. Rather,

these are the constructs that both share these motives and have been studied widely and consistently enough within the UPB literature that they are amenable to meta-analysis.

Attitudes about and Perceptions of the Workplace

For the prosocial perspective, the first four constructs we considered represent employees' attitudes about and perceptions of their workplaces. The prosocial perspective would be more strongly supported to the extent that UPB positively correlates with other constructs that reflect feeling or acting out of a sense of duty and loyalty. Social exchange theory (Blau, 1964) suggests that relationships develop into more trusting and loyal commitments over time as parties abide by rules of exchange. The most prominent of these rules is reciprocity. When employees perceive that their employer has fulfilled its duties, employees feel obligated to fulfill their own. Over time, exchanges that are seen as favorable foster positive attitudes (Cropanzano & Mitchell, 2005). For example, employees who perceive that their organization is supportive return this support in the form of increased organizational commitment (Kurtessis et al., 2017). Similarly, perceived organizational support enhances employees' job satisfaction because their expectations of reciprocity are met (Rhoades & Eisenberger, 2002). Equitable exchanges also form the basis of organizational justice (Colquitt et al., 2013), such that being treated fairly increases perceptions of organizational justice.

Taken together, higher organizational commitment, perceived organizational justice, and job satisfaction all occur in response to employers fulfilling their duties. The prosocial perspective suggests that positive social exchange also fosters UPB (Umphress & Bingham, 2011). Thus, the prosocial perspective of UPB leads one to expect a positive relationship between UPB and these constructs.

> *Hypothesis 1 (H1): Unethical pro-organizational behavior will be positively related to organizational commitment.*

Hypothesis 2 (H2): Unethical pro-organizational behavior will be positively related to organizational justice.
Hypothesis 3 (H3): Unethical pro-organizational behavior will be positively related to job satisfaction.

In addition to social exchange theory (Blau, 1964), the prosocial perspective of UPB also relies on social identity theory (Ashforth & Mael, 1989; Tajfel & Turner, 1986). Social identity theory suggests that an individual's self-concept is in part based on one's membership in social groups (Tajfel & Turner, 1986), a salient one of which is an individual's employer (Ashforth & Mael, 1989). When people strongly identify with a group, they are motivated to see the group succeed and will devote effort towards advancing the group's interests. Accordingly, individuals with strong group identity tend to perform better as a group (C. Lee et al., 2011). Similarly, employees who strongly identify with their organizations exhibit higher task performance and extra-role performance (E.-S. Lee et al., 2015). At times, this effort may also manifest as UPB, because employees with stronger group or organizational identity are more likely to reframe UPB as necessary or even dutiful (Iyer et al., 2012; Umphress & Bingham, 2011). Thus, consistent with the prosocial perspective, we hypothesize:

Hypothesis 4 (H4): Unethical pro-organizational behavior will be positively related to group identity.
Hypothesis 5 (H5): Unethical pro-organizational behavior will be positively related to organizational identity.

One of the key antecedents to group or organizational identity—and subsequently acting to advance the collective's interests—is the perception that one holds shared values (Edwards & Cable, 2009; Kristof-Brown et al., 2005). Perceived value alignment is the degree to which one's own values are similar to those of the organization (Kristof, 1996). When value alignment is high, individuals feel attracted to and more committed to the organization (Edwards & Cable,

2009). Consequently, they are more likely to act in ways they believe will benefit the organization. Consistent with the prosocial perspective, we hypothesize the following:

> *Hypothesis 6 (H6): Unethical pro-organizational behavior will be positively related to value alignment.*

Relationship with One's Supervisor

In accordance with the prosocial perspective, employees' relationships with their supervisors should also influence UPB. Just as employees engage in social exchanges with their employer, so too do they have social exchanges with their supervisors (Cropanzano & Mitchell, 2005). These distinct exchanges result in target-specific responses (Rupp et al., 2014), such that, for example, the quality of employees' social exchange with their supervisors will influence behaviors and attitudes directed specifically towards their supervisors. These exchanges with supervisors also result in non-target-specific responses to the organization as a whole, likely because, from the perspective of employees, supervisors embody the organization (Colquitt et al., 2013). The quality of leader–follower relationships is often referred to as leader–member exchange (LMX) (Wayne et al., 1997). Over time, positive exchanges produce higher quality relationships, while negative exchanges produce lower quality relationships. When employees have higher quality relationships with their supervisors, they are more willing to engage in behaviors beyond their prescribed roles in order to pay back their supervisors and their organizations (Ilies et al., 2007). Thus, the prosocial perspective would suggest the following hypothesis:

> *Hypothesis 7 (H7): Unethical pro-organizational behavior will be positively related to LMX.*

Organizational Citizenship Behavior

In addition to being related to antecedent constructs that may influence UPB, the prosocial perspective also suggests that UPB could be related to other behavioral constructs that share similar duty and obligation motives, such as organizational citizenship behavior (OCB). OCB refers to tasks employees perform that go beyond their formal job role and contribute to the organization's success (Borman & Motowidlo, 1997). It is clear from the definitions of OCB and UPB that these constructs bear similarity (Mishra et al., 2022): they both involve discretionary behaviors and the intention of benefiting the organization. The key difference, of course, is that only UPB specifies that the behaviors are unethical, whereas this is not necessarily the case for OCB. In addition to their conceptual similarity, OCB and UPB share common theoretical antecedents. Prior work has shown that, like UPB, positive social exchange (Konovsky & Pugh, 1994) and organizational identity (E.-S. Lee et al., 2015) are reasons that employees engage in OCB. Given the conceptual overlap between OCB and UPB and the shared theoretical foundation between OCB and the prosocial perspective of UPB, we hypothesize the following:

> *Hypothesis 8 (H8): Unethical pro-organizational behavior will be positively related to organizational citizenship behavior.*

The Self-Interest Perspective

Self-interest, when unrestrained, involves "aims that refer only to end states or conditions of the self and are considered worthy to pursue even at the expense of others" (Folger, 2001, p. 10). The self-interest perspective we propose here is based on behavioral decision theory (Edwards, 1961; Loewenstein, 1996; Shafir & LeBoeuf, 2002), which suggests that people are motivated to make decisions that maximize their self-interests. They maximize their self-interests by engaging in cognitive processes to assess the expected value of the available choices, then choosing the option that most satisfies one's interests. Thus, this perspective suggests that

employees engage in UPB because they perceive it as beneficial to themselves, and that people are willing to act unethically provided that the expected value of the behavior is sufficiently high.

The self-interest perspective, therefore, suggests that UPB should be related to other constructs that share this motivational basis of maximizing one's self-interests (e.g., improve one's reputation, get greater compensation), even at the cost of harming others. Of the constructs in UPB's nomological network, the following most clearly tap into a similar motivational basis: namely, certain dispositional traits (i.e., careerism, Machiavellianism, narcissism, and psychological entitlement), perceptions of threat (i.e., self-threat and job insecurity), perceptions of organizational politics, and counterproductive work behavior. Like with the prosocial perspective, we do not make the case that these are the only constructs in UPB's nomological network that might share a motive of self-interest. Rather, these are the constructs that both share this motive and have been studied widely and consistently enough within the UPB literature that they are amenable to meta-analysis.

Dispositional Traits

A variety of personality traits have been implicated in predisposing people to engage in harmful acts for one's own benefit (Bettencourt et al., 2006). We focus on those that have been shown to predispose employees toward harming others as a means to achieve their self-interested ends. Several dispositional traits in UPB's nomological network fit this profile: careerism, Machiavellianism, narcissism, and psychological entitlement. While all of these traits reflect seeking personal gain irrespective of the effects it has on others, each trait captures a unique way in which this is achieved (Moshagen et al., 2018).

Careerism (also referred to as career self-interest) is a person's propensity to pursue advancing their career through non-performance-based means (Feldman & Weitz, 1991). People

high in this attribute believe that it is difficult to succeed based on merit alone, so career success requires leveraging social relationships, using deception, and prioritizing one's own interests in order to get ahead (Feldman & Weitz, 1991). High careerism is also associated with a short-term orientation (Bratton & Kacmar, 2004). Thus, people high in careerism may be more likely to use unethical means to increase their chances of quick advancement. They identify and engage in behaviors that are formally rewarded by the organization without concern for how much value for the organization is actually being created by those behaviors (Park & Sturman, 2021). For instance, careerist employees may defraud customers to become more successful in their individual roles. Incidentally, in the short-term, this behavior will also benefit the organization, but if this fraudulent behavior is uncovered, the organization will be penalized. For the careerist employee, it is unlikely this is a significant concern because they have little loyalty to the organization (Feldman & Weitz, 1991). Therefore, consistent with the self-interest perspective, we hypothesize:

> *Hypothesis 9 (H9): Unethical pro-organizational behavior will be positively related to careerism.*

Machiavellianism reflects a tendency towards manipulativeness, callous affect, and a strategic-calculating orientation (Jones & Paulhus, 2014). People high in Machiavellianism prioritize their self-interests and believe that the ends justify the means (Christie & Geis, 1970). Consequently, they are more likely to engage in unethical behaviors at work (Kish-Gephart et al., 2010). While Machiavellians are generally less likely to engage in positive reciprocation (Gunnthorsdottir et al., 2002) and prosocial behaviors (McHoskey, 1999), they may be willing to perform UPBs if they view it as an opportunity for their own gain (Castille et al., 2018). For example, Machiavellians may conceal damaging information about their organizations in order

to protect their own reputations and ensure their employers and, by extension, their jobs survive. Thus, consistent with the self-interest perspective, we hypothesize:

> *Hypothesis 10 (H10): Unethical pro-organizational behavior will be positively related to Machiavellianism.*

Narcissism reflects a set of behaviors in which the overriding motive is enhancing one's grandiose sense of self (Back et al., 2013). Individuals high in narcissism have a sense of entitlement, believing the usual rules and standards do not apply to them (O'Boyle et al., 2012). Thus, people high in narcissism are much more likely to engage in unethical behavior if it advances their self-interest and bolsters their grandiose sense of self. For example, of the Dark Triad personality traits, narcissism is most strongly related to counterproductive work behavior (O'Boyle et al., 2012). There are at least a couple of reasons narcissists would see UPB as being in their self-interest. First, UPB can be a means to enhance one's image in a group (Thau et al., 2015), which would play into a narcissist's motive to enhance their grandiose sense of self. Second, those high in narcissism are very sensitive to perceived personal slights or criticism, as this is antithetical to their inflated self-views. Therefore, they are particularly likely to respond to such slights or criticism with aggression (Bushman & Baumeister, 1998). For example, in response to a rude or critical customer or client, someone high in narcissism might be especially likely to respond with UPB, such as by withholding a discount or secretly not providing a service that was paid for. For these reasons we expect employees higher in narcissism to be more likely to engage in UPB than employees lower in narcissism. Therefore, following the self-interest perspective, we hypothesize:

> *Hypothesis 11 (H11): Unethical pro-organizational behavior will be positively related to narcissism.*

Psychological entitlement refers to a pervasive belief that one deserves more than others (Campbell et al., 2004). Because of this core belief, highly entitled people are more likely to act selfishly across a variety of contexts, including negotiations, romantic relationships, and resource allocation tasks (Campbell et al., 2004). For entitled individuals, pursuing self-interests at the cost of others may not be perceived as unethical because they are justly deserving of the outcomes they seek (Zitek et al., 2010). For example, an entitled salesperson may feel he or she deserves the extra commission, even if he or she must overcharge a customer in order to earn it. Entitled people also have a higher tendency to blame others for the negative outcomes they experience (Harvey & Martinko, 2009). Feeling wronged by others increases the likelihood of responding with the intent to harm (Anderson & Bushman, 2002). For instance, to retaliate against a belligerent customer, an entitled employee may withhold a discount or provide inaccurate information about one's organization. Thus, consistent with the self-interest perspective, we hypothesize the following:

> *Hypothesis 12 (H12): Unethical pro-organizational behavior will be positively related to psychological entitlement.*

Perceptions of Threat

Actions that harm others, such as UPB, often occur in response to provocations, which refers to "actions or situations that are aversive or stressful" (Bettencourt et al., 2006, p. 752). In some cases, provocations produce acute responses, wherein individuals quickly react to address the threatening or anger-inducing actions of another person (e.g., an employee refusing to give an advertised discount to a rude customer). In other cases, provocations produce a delayed response, wherein individuals plan how to address the provocation before engaging in any action. In the latter cases, harming others may not itself be the goal, but rather a means to rectifying a situation. For example, if a salesperson is performing poorly and is concerned about

losing his or her job, this person may use deceptive sales tactics to improve their standing. While this behavior may be done in part to benefit the organization, it also serves the salesperson's self-interests. The two constructs we examined next are provocations in the sense that they are stressful or aversive situations. According to the self-interest perspective of UPB, we would expect them to positively correlate with UPB because these provocations motivate people to prioritize self-interests, even at the cost of others.

The first provocation we consider is self-threat. Self-threat refers to the perception that "favorable views about oneself are … in jeopardy" (Baumeister et al., 1996, p. 8), and this perception has both trait-like and state-like elements. One aspect of the self that can be threatened is one's group identity. Because people are motivated to identify with groups that reflect positively on themselves (Tajfel & Turner, 1986), they will defend against people or situations that threaten these affiliations. This defense may come in the form of reasserting one's group identity by increasing one's contribution to the group (C. M. Steele et al., 2002). The means of making these pro-group contributions may take both ethical and unethical forms. For example, Thau et al. (2015) found that when people were worried about being excluded from their workgroups, they were more likely to cheat to benefit those same workgroups. Thus, consistent with the self-interest perspective, we propose that employees will engage in UPB in response to self-threats to satisfy their interests in maintaining a group identity.

> *Hypothesis 13 (H13): Unethical pro-organizational behavior will be positively related to perceptions of self-threat.*

The second provocation we consider is job insecurity, defined as a "perceived threat to the continuity and stability of employment as it is currently experienced" (Shoss, 2017, p. 1914). Given the importance of employment to most workers, in response to this threat, employees are motivated to act in ways that they believe will mitigate the threat and preserve their current

employment situation. For example, employees may work harder and engage in more OCBs as a means to gain favor from more senior employees (Shoss & Probst, 2012). Of course, in fear of job loss, giving extra effort may take unethical forms as well (L. M. Steele et al., 2020). Thus, consistent with the self-interest perspective, when employees experience job insecurity, we expect that they will be more likely to engage in UPB as a means of preserving their jobs.

> *Hypothesis 14 (H14): Unethical pro-organizational behavior will be positively related to job insecurity.*

Perceptions of Organizational Politics

One contextual factor that may foster self-interested behavior such as UPB is perceptions of organizational politics. Perceived organizational politics refers to employees' evaluation about the degree to which their work environment is characterized by self-serving behavior (Ferris et al., 2019). When employees perceive that it is the norm to act out of self-interest, they are more likely to adopt these behaviors themselves. Furthermore, in political environments, self-serving behavior is often practiced without regard for how it may harm others (Ferris et al., 1989), increasing the perceived utility of pursuing one's self-interests through unethical means. In other words, political environments narrow one's frame of mind to considering only how oneself can benefit, which increases the motivation to maximize personal gain (Park & Sturman, 2021). Thus, based on the self-interest perspective of UPB, we hypothesize:

> *Hypothesis 15 (H15): Unethical pro-organizational behavior will be positively related to perceptions of organizational politics.*

Counterproductive Workplace Behavior

The final construct we examined for the self-interest perspective of UPB was counterproductive workplace behavior (CWB). CWB is defined as behavior that harms an organization or its stakeholders (Spector & Fox, 2005). CWB and UPB share an intention to do

harm, including at times, to similar stakeholder groups (i.e., customers). According to the prosocial perspective (Umphress & Bingham, 2011), a key distinction between the two behaviors is that UPB has a different motivational underpinning (i.e., positive social exchange and social identity) than CWB. However, our proposed self-interested perspective suggests that UPB and CWB have a common, rather than distinct, motivational underpinning (i.e., self-interest). Thus, the self-interest perspective suggests that CWB and UPB not only manifest in similar ways (i.e., harming customers), but also have a common motivational foundation of self-interest (Vardi & Wiener, 1996). As a result, consistent with the self-interest perspective, we hypothesize that CWB and UPB will be positively correlated.

> *Hypothesis 16 (H16): Unethical pro-organizational behavior will be positively related to counterproductive workplace behavior.*

Summary

The prosocial perspective suggests that employees engaging in UPB do so primarily out of a sense of duty due to their positive social exchange relationship and/or strong identity with their organization. To the extent that this perspective is supported, we would expect UPB to be positively related to organizational commitment, job satisfaction, organizational identity, and group identity; higher perceptions of organizational justice and alignment of values; higher positive exchange relationships; and higher likelihood of engaging in OCB. The self-interest perspective paints a somewhat different picture. It suggests employees engage in UPB more so (albeit, not exclusively) out of self-interest. To the extent this perspective is supported, we would expect UPB to be positively related to perceptions that one's organization is charged with self-interested political behavior; to perceptions that one is in aversive and stressful situations (i.e., "threats") that incentivize self-interested responses; to possessing high standing on traits that predispose oneself to justify harm as means to achieving self-interested ends; and to be

particularly likely to engage in CWB. It is possible that one perspective fits UPB better than the other, or even that both provide valid, complementary views of UPB. The present meta-analysis, with its comprehensive summary of the nomological network of UPB, allows for a powerful test of these two perspectives.

Broader Nomological Network

In addition to the abovementioned constructs in UPB's nomological network, in an exploratory fashion, the present study meta-analyzed the relationships between UPB and any construct with which it had been related in at least three samples. This was done for the sake of comprehensiveness and to provide a summary of the full nomological network of UPB in the literature to date.

Method

Transparency and Openness

This study was not submitted for IRB approval because we did not collect data from participants. We describe next the literature search procedure and inclusion criteria we used in this meta-analysis. We adhered to the *Journal of Applied Psychology*'s methodological checklist. The data are available in the Meta-Analysis Data Online Supplement. The analysis code for the effect size calculations and exploratory moderator analyses are available at https://osf.io/w7mzf/?view_only=6a62669ebf624e4686e12340e20c608d. The study's design and its analyses were not preregistered.

Identification of Studies

Our literature search was conducted in July 2020. First, we used the "cited by" feature in Google Scholar to search all papers that had cited Umphress et al.'s (2010) scale development paper. Given that these authors introduced the construct and first measure of UPB, we expected

the majority of studies of interest to cite this original work. Second, we conducted a keyword search using the terms "unethical pro-organizational behavior," "unethical prosocial behavior," "organizational illegality," "corporate crime," "corrupt organization," and "illegal corporate behavior" on PsycInfo, ABI/INFORM, Business Source Premier, and Google Scholar.[1] Third, we reviewed the 2018, 2019, and 2020 annual conference programs for the Academy of Management and Society of Industrial–Organizational Psychology. Finally, we posted a request for unpublished data on the Academy of Management's Human Resources listserv and Organizational Behavior listserv.

For studies to be included in this meta-analysis, we applied the following inclusion criteria: (a) written in English, (b) includes only adults (age > 18 years) in the sample, (c) measures the relationship between UPB and another construct, and (d) reports an effect size or sufficient information to compute an effect size. After applying these criteria, 94 papers were included (68 published, 26 unpublished), which consisted of 139 independent samples. Figure 1 presents a flowchart depicting the study identification process.

For a study to be included, the measure of UPB had to conform to Umphress and Bingham's (2011) definition. In the vast majority of cases, the measure of UPB was Umphress et al.'s (2010) scale. In some instances, authors used Umphress et al.'s scale, but labeled what they were measuring as "unethical behavior" and not specifically "unethical pro-organizational behavior" (e.g., Bonner et al., 2017; Jiang et al., 2016). We decided to retain these studies because the contents of the measure reflected UPB.

In some cases, the measure of UPB consisted of unethical behaviors that benefit the organization, but did not include an explicit mention of the intention to benefit the organization

[1] The latter five search terms were included based on Vadera and Pratt's (2013) typology of workplace crimes, which grouped UPB with the other behaviors included in our search.

with one's unethical behavior. Of the 139 studies included in this meta-analysis, 117 were coded as explicitly measuring intentions to benefit the organization or its members. Of the 22 studies that did not have an explicit mention of intentions, 10 measured UPB by observing participants' behavior. For example, Hildreth et al. (2016) observed the frequency with which participants would cheat in order to monetarily benefit a group to which they had been assigned or already belonged. The other 12 studies that lacked an explicit mention of intentions (e.g., Bonner et al., 2017; Johnson & Umphress, 2019, Study 1; Miao & Wang, 2017) used survey measures of UPB. The effect sizes obtained in these 22 studies where intentions were implicit are largely consistent (i.e., falling within a single standard deviation of the mean effect size for a given relationship) with effect sizes obtained in studies where intentions are explicit. Thus, we decided to retain these studies as well.

--- Insert Figure 1 about here ---

Coding

All studies were coded by either the first or second author. To ensure the studies would be coded consistently between the two coders, we first prepared a detailed codebook that defined each piece of information that would be coded. First, this codebook included study identification information, such as the first author, sample number, and year of publication. Second, the codebook included definitions of all the constructs included in our hypotheses and the broader nomological network. These definitions guided our decision to group some constructs that may have used different labels across studies. For example, we coded all of the following as *organizational commitment*: "organizational commitment," "affective organizational commitment," and "workgroup commitment." For constructs included in our hypotheses, a list of the construct definitions and operationalizations are in Table 1. For constructs in the broader

nomological network, definitions and operationalizations are in the Construct Definitions Online Supplement. Gender was coded as 0 = males, 1 = females. Third, the codebook included information relevant to the effect size: correlation, sample size, and measure reliability. When more than one usable effect size for a given relationship was available in a study, we computed a composite score and reliability coefficient (Hunter & Schmidt, 2014). Fourth, the codebook included information about how constructs were conceptualized and measured, including whether the non-UPB construct was an antecedent or consequence to UPB, whether the UPB measure reflected intentions or behavior, who the target of the UPB was (e.g., organization, supervisor), and the measure used to capture UPB. Finally, the codebook included methodological information, such as the study design (i.e., cross-sectional, time-lagged, or experimental), rating source (i.e., self or other), and country from which sample was drawn.

--- Insert Table 1 about here ---

After reviewing the codebook, we independently selected three articles to code, then met to discuss discrepancies. We repeated this process four times with 3-5 articles each time. Seventeen articles were double-coded, which included 22 samples and 2,888 pieces of coding information (i.e., all of the information described earlier in this paragraph across 152 rows of effect sizes). In the final set of articles we coded, our agreement was 95.33%, which reflects the frequency with which both coders entered 950 pieces of coding information across 50 rows of effect sizes drawn from five studies in exactly the same way. The remaining studies were randomly divided in half and assigned to the two coders.

Data Analysis

The effect size statistic used in this meta-analysis is the correlation coefficient (*r*). We corrected effect sizes for attenuation using the internal consistency coefficients (α) reported in

each study. When a study did not report reliability for a variable, we used the average reliability reported in other studies for that variable. Analyses were conducted using the Hunter-Schmidt setting in the "psychmeta" R package (Dahlke & Wiernik, 2019). We computed the following statistics: the weighted mean observed correlations ($\bar{r}$) and between-study standard deviations (SD_r), the weighted mean corrected correlations (ρ) and between-study standard deviations (SD_ρ), 95% confidence intervals (95% CI_ρ), and 80% credibility intervals (80% CV_ρ). Confidence intervals show the precision of the estimated mean effect size, while credibility intervals show the dispersion of effect sizes across studies.

Results

Prosocial Perspective

We tested the relationships between UPB and the constructs included in the prosocial perspective (i.e., H1-H8). We interpreted a hypothesis as supported if the observed correlation was in the expected direction and the 95% confidence interval did not overlap with zero. We first examined the relationship between UPB and employees' attitudes about and perceptions of the workplace. As shown in Table 2, the relationships between UPB and organizational commitment (ρ = .06, 95% *CI* = [-.08, .21]), organizational justice (ρ = .05, 95% *CI* = [-.08, .18]), group identity (ρ = .01, 95% *CI* = [-.06, .09]), and value alignment (ρ = .05, 95% *CI* = [-.06, .16]) all had 95% confidence intervals including zero, but in the relationships between UPB and job satisfaction (ρ = .13, 95% *CI* = [.07, .20]) and organizational identity (ρ = .19, 95% *CI* = [.14, .24]), the 95% confidence intervals did not include zero. These results did not support H1, H2, H4, and H6, but they did support H3 and H5. Next, we examined a construct that reflected employees' relationships with their supervisors. In the relationship between UPB and LMX (ρ = .12, 95% *CI* = [-.02, .27]), the 95% confidence intervals included zero, which did not support H7.

The final construct we considered in the prosocial perspective was OCB. In the relationship between UPB and OCB (ρ = -.07, 95% *CI* = [-.15, .02]), the 95% confidence interval included zero, which did not support H8. Taken together, two of the eight hypotheses in the prosocial perspective were supported.

--- Insert Table 2 about here ---

Self-Interest Perspective

We then tested the relationships between UPB and the constructs included in the self-interest perspective (i.e., H9-H16). Within the self-interest perspective, we first examined the relationship between UPB and four dispositional traits. UPB was positively related to careerism (ρ = .24, 95% *CI* = [.18, .29]), Machiavellianism (ρ = .41, 95% *CI* = [.29, .53]), narcissism (ρ = .37, 95% *CI* = [.30, .45]), and psychological entitlement (ρ = .48, 95% *CI* = [.18, .79]). None of the 95% confidence intervals included zero, thus, all the hypotheses concerning the dispositional traits (i.e., H9-H12) were supported. Next, we examined the relationships between UPB and two constructs that reflected different forms of perceived threats. In the relationship between UPB and perceived self-threat (ρ = .08, 95% *CI* = [-.07, .24]), the 95% confidence interval included zero. In the relationship between UPB and job insecurity (ρ = .25, 95% *CI* = [.16, .33]), the 95% confidence interval did not include zero. These results do not support H13, but they do support H14. We then tested the relationship between perceptions of organizational politics and UPB (ρ = .31, 95% *CI* = [.23, .39]). The 95% confidence interval did not include zero, which supported H15. The final construct we considered in the self-interest perspective was CWB. The relationship between UPB and CWB was positive (ρ = .53, 95% *CI* = [.44, .62]) and the 95% confidence interval did not include zero, supporting H16. Taken together, seven of the eight hypotheses in the self-interest perspective were supported.

Broader Nomological Network

In our review of the literature, we observed relationships between UPB and other constructs that did not fit clearly within either the prosocial or self-interest perspectives of UPB (see Table 3). We present them here to provide insight into the broader nomological network of the UPB construct. Of the five demographic variables we examined, four very small relationships were observed where the 95% confidence interval did not include zero: job level was positively correlated (ρ = .07, 95% *CI* = [.00, .15]), age was negatively correlated (ρ = -.08, 95% *CI* = [-.11, -.05]) as was tenure (ρ = -.04, 95% *CI* = [-.07, -.01]), and females were less likely than males to engage in UPB or report intentions to do so (ρ = -.05, 95% *CI* = [-.08, -.02]). Of the variables in the broader nomological network in Table 3, moral disengagement (ρ = .51, 95% *CI* = [.39, .63]) and conscientiousness (ρ = -.44, 95% *CI* = [-.54, -.35]) were most strongly related to UPB, although the conscientiousness correlation was only based on three samples. The rest of the constructs correlated at least ±.20 with UPB were supervisor bottom-line mentality (ρ = .29, 95% *CI* = [.16, .41]), instrumental climate (ρ = .28, 95% *CI* = [.21, .34]), supervisor UPB (ρ = .27, 95% *CI* = [.22, .32]), identification with leader (ρ = .25, 95% *CI* = [.12, .37]), general ethical behavior (ρ = .20, 95% *CI* = [-.15, .54]), and moral courage (ρ = -.20, 95% *CI* = [-.33, -.06]). The remaining constructs had relatively weak relationships with UPB. Surprisingly, ethical organizational climate (ρ = -.11, 95% *CI* = [-.22, -.01]), ethical leadership (ρ = .05, 95% *CI* = [-.03, .14]), and social desirability (ρ = -.06, 95% *CI* = [-.16, .04]) were among these constructs with relatively weak relationships.

--- Insert Table 3 about here ---

Although the predominant focus in the UPB literature has been on antecedents, a few studies have examined the consequences of this behavior. Specifically, four studies manipulated

whether UPB was done to benefit oneself or others (e.g., one's organization, a teammate), then they measured participants' intention to punish this behavior. Across the four studies, we observed a small negative relationship between UPB and recommended punishment (ρ = -.15, 95% *CI* = [-.24, -.05]), indicating that people recommend less severe punishments for unethical behavior done for prosocial, rather than self-interested, reasons.

Publication Bias Tests

We tested for publication bias using the trim and fill technique (Duval & Tweedie, 2000). The trim and fill technique examines the extent to which the distribution of effect sizes is asymmetrical, trims the number of studies needed to achieve a symmetrical distribution, then fills the number of studies that are missing potentially due to publication bias. The results of the trim and fill analysis generally showed small differences (i.e., a difference of less than ± .05) between the trim-and-fill corrected effect sizes and the original effect sizes. Among the hypothesized relationships, there was one exception: the trim-and-fill corrected effect size for organizational commitment was ρ = .21 (95% *CI* = [.02, .34]), while the original estimate was ρ = .06 (95% *CI* = [-.08, .21]). The corrected effect size has a 95% confidence interval that does not include zero, which suggests that Hypothesis 1 should be supported, not rejected. Nevertheless, after conducting the trim and fill analysis, the overall interpretation of results remains the same. Please see Trim and Fill Analyses Online Supplement for the full results.

Exploratory Moderator Analysis: Behaviors vs. Intentions

In addition to testing the hypotheses described above, we also explored the role of an important methodological moderator—namely, does the predominant measure of UPB reflect intentions or behaviors? Social scientists have expressed concern for decades about the gap between intention and behavior (Sheeran, 2002). This issue is particularly relevant to the UPB

literature because of the way in which the most commonly used UPB scale was initially constructed (Umphress et al., 2010). That is, although the scale purports to measure *behavior*, the items, in fact, reflect intentions (e.g., "If it would help my organization, I would misrepresent the truth to make my organization look good."). The majority of studies simply use Umphress et al.'s scale as is, and measure UPB as intentions; however, in some cases, authors have modified the scale to reflect self-reported behaviors (e.g., Johnson & Umphress, 2019). In other cases, the scale is not used at all and UPB is instead measured through observation of employee behaviors (e.g., Baur et al., 2020). This variation in measurement provides an opportunity to learn more about the nature of the UPB construct and answers a call made in a recent qualitative review of the UPB literature (Mo et al., 2022).

We used categorical moderator analyses to test whether the relationship between UPB and other constructs varied significantly according to whether UPB was measured as intention or behavior. We only conducted these analyses when at least two studies were represented in each category (Valentine et al., 2010). Consistent with Aguinis, Sturman, and Pierce's (2008) recommendation, we evaluated the statistical significance of a moderator test by comparing the significance of the difference between the correlations for the two moderator categories using a *t*-test with $k_1 - k_2$ degrees of freedom, where k_1 and k_2 refer to the number of samples in the two moderator categories (i.e., number of samples for intentions versus behaviors).

Twenty-two constructs had a sufficient *k*-size for us to examine this moderator (see Table 4). Of the 22 constructs, the moderator test was statistically significant for four. For one of the four constructs (i.e., trait moral disengagement), the correlation was stronger when UPB was measured as intention (ρ's of .57 versus .32). For two of the four constructs, the correlation was stronger when UPB was measured as behavior: ethical climate (ρ's of -.29 versus -.09) and self-

control (ρ's of -.29 versus .00). For one of the four constructs (i.e., ethical leadership), the correlation with UPB was in opposite directions when UPB was measured as intention (ρ = .08) versus behavior (ρ = -.14). In all, the behavior versus intention distinction does not affect most relationships and when it does, there is not a clear pattern to whether relationships with UPB are stronger when it is conceptualized as behavior versus intentions.

--- Insert Table 4 about here ---

Discussion

Theoretical Implications

Our meta-analysis offers several insights into UPB. First, we reevaluate the role of self-interest in motivating UPB, which engenders a starkly different understanding of UPB relative to existing theory. In the decade since its inception, UPB has been understood primarily as a prosocially motivated behavior: employees engage in UPB to reciprocate positive exchanges with their employer or out of loyalty to an employer with which they identify. However, we found modest evidence to support this conceptualization. For example, the average of the absolute values of the correlations between UPB and the prosocial constructs was .09. In contrast, the self-interest perspective, which posits self-interest maximization as a motive of UPB, was better supported by the evidence in this meta-analysis. For example, the relationships that UPB had with the self-interested constructs were all in the hypothesized direction and the average of the absolute values of those correlations was .33. Our results suggest that UPB may be better understood as primarily a means of advancing one's self-interests regardless of the harm done to others. UPB is less a matter of "when employees do bad things for good reasons" than it is another manifestation of personal and contextual characteristics that foster unethical behavior (Kish-Gephart et al., 2010; Treviño et al., 2014).

Another implication of the present study is that the two perspectives of UPB we discussed can more fully explain UPB when examined together. While one perspective of UPB explains more variance than the other (Leavitt et al., 2010), the two perspectives are not mutually exclusive. Indeed, considering prosocial and self-interest motives together offers an opportunity to more powerfully explain UPB (De Dreu, 2006; Grant, 2009). One perspective may serve as a better explanation under certain conditions, or they could be used in tandem. Just as OCB is influenced by a variety of motives (Bolino et al., 2016), UPB appears likely to be as well. For example, when Siemens, the largest industrial manufacturing firm in Europe, was fined $1.6 billion in 2006 for bribing government officials, a mid-level executive explained, “It was about keeping the business unit alive and not jeopardizing thousands of jobs overnight” (Schubert & Miller, 2008, para. 9). This statement shows what may often be the case for UPB—namely, that prosocial and self-interests coexist. By integrating the prosocial and self-interest perspectives we have presented here, scholars have a richer understanding of who, when, and why employees engage in UPB.

Given the relevance of self-interest motives to engaging in UPB, there is a need to revisit Umphress and Bingham’s (2011) definition. According to their original definition, an unethical action can only be considered UPB when it is done with the primary intention of benefiting the organization or its members. However, our results show that self-interest plays an important and more prominent role in motivating unethical actions that benefit one’s organization or its members. Consequently, according to Umphress and Bingham’s prosocial-dominant definition, UPB may be less common than originally thought. In light of the evidence from the present study, we suggest that even when self-interest is a dominant motive, unethical actions that benefit one’s organization or its members should also fall under the purview of UPB. Thus, we

offer the following revised definition of UPB: *actions that are intended to provide some benefit to the organization or its members (even if they are also partially or primarily intended to benefit the self), but which violate core societal values, mores, laws, or standards of proper conduct*.[2]

This revised definition reflects two important changes. First, this definition states explicitly the potential role of self-interest, highlighting the findings of the present meta-analysis and clarifying a point that has been discussed in recent primary studies (Lee et al., 2019; Naseer et al., 2020) and qualitative reviews (Mishra et al., 2022; Mo et al., 2022). Thus, unethical actions done with at least some intention to benefit the organization, regardless of whether self-interest is a person's *primary* motivation or not, would all be considered UPB. Second, we use the expression "provide some benefit to" rather than "promote the effective functioning of" to better align with the varied motives permitted under the revised definition. In particular, when people engage in UPB for largely self-interested reasons, we suggest that while the organization may benefit (at least in the short term), the organization may or may not function more effectively. For instance, an employee who is defrauding customers or lying about competitors may be helping close a sale, but it is a bit of stretch to suggest that this employee is making the organization function more effectively. Furthermore, using the phrase "provide some benefit" in the definition still allows UPB to be distinct from what Vadera and Pratt (2013) refer to as *deviance* or *unethical behavior*—that is, actions that deliberately harm the organization and/or its members. Thus, for example, if a bank employee were to funnel customer funds into their own

[2] A similar change was made for OCB in the 1990s when, after the accumulation of evidence, a part of the definition was revised. Specifically, in Organ's (1988) original definition, he stated that OCB cannot be "directly or formally recompensed by the organization's reward system" (p. 5). However, subsequent research showed that extra-role behaviors can and do influence performance appraisals (Podsakoff et al., 2009), which led to the question, should only *unrewarded* extra-role behaviors be considered OCB? Organ (1997) decided to remove from the definition of OCB the requirement that the behavior be without formal rewards.

personal account, this behavior would not be considered UPB because it lacks the potential to benefit the organization.

Another implication of integrating the prosocial and self-interest perspectives is new insight into *how* these antecedents may foster UPB. According to the prosocial perspective (Umphress & Bingham, 2011), the key mechanism linking organizational identity and positive social exchange with UPB is moral disengagement (which they call "neutralization"), which refers to "cognitive reasoning processes through which people selectively reconstrue a moral judgment" about a given behavior being morally wrong (Schaefer & Bouwmeester, 2021, p. 532). We suggest that moral disengagement may be a more relevant explanatory mechanism when the behavior in question is clearly immoral. Our results on observer-recommended punishment showed that UPB was punished less severely when UPB was done for primarily prosocial reasons, which suggests that it was seen as less of an ethical violation than UPB done for primarily self-interested reasons. Corroborating evidence is found in studies showing that when benefiting others (rather than solely oneself) through unethical means, people experience less guilt (Gino et al., 2013) and lower physiological arousal (Hochman et al., 2021). Thus, UPB driven by primarily prosocial reasons may not require moral disengagement to the same extent as UPB driven primarily by self-interest because the former can be seen as the morally right thing to do (Graham et al., 2020).

Of the constructs that have been examined using the prosocial perspective (Umphress & Bingham, 2011), organizational identity has received by far the most scholarly attention. Given its popularity, one might assume that organizational identity would be a strong predictor of UPB, yet we found that it had a modest (average ρ = .19) and highly variant (credibility interval ranging from -.01 to .38, suggesting its relationship can be expected to range from null to

moderately-to-strongly positive) effect. However, some studies have found that organizational identity interacted with constructs such as inter-organizational competition (Chen et al., 2016) or reciprocity beliefs (Umphress et al., 2010). Taken together, these findings suggest that organizational identity alone may not be sufficient to foster UPB; instead, it appears to depend on other, enabling conditions, whether they be individual differences (e.g., Machiavellianism; Castille et al., 2018) or contextual factors (e.g., inter-group competition; Chen et al., 2016). One reason for this may be that the strength of one's organizational identity only suggests that people will act consistently with the interests of their employers; it does not, however, illuminate the means by which people will do so. The latter is shaped by what members of the organization reinforce as acceptable behavior. The key distinction here is between identity *strength* (or importance) and identity *content* (Ashmore et al., 2004). Identity content refers to how a group defines itself. It is an organization's self-attributed characteristics and shared values, beliefs, and narratives. Unless an organization endorses "doing whatever it takes to win," employees who strongly identify with that organization are not likely to act unethically on its behalf because it would not be consistent with their organization's identity (L. M. Steele & Lovelace, 2023). Evidence supportive of this idea is the relationships UPB has with contextual variables in this meta-analysis such as perceptions of organizational politics and supervisor bottom-line mentality. These contextual variables send signals to employees that acting in one's self-interest and doing whatever it takes to support the organization are normative, and these contextual variables have sizable positive relationships with UPB.

Finally, the results of our exploratory moderator analyses have a couple implications. Answering a call for research in Mo et al.(2022), our analysis of the methodological moderator shows that the nomological network of UPB is largely consistent whether UPB is measured as

intentions or behaviors. Given the gap typically observed between intentions and behaviors generally (Bosco et al., 2015; Sheeran, 2002), this was a surprising finding. This means that the evidence to date does not suggest scholars need to be particularly concerned about whether the items in instruments measuring UPB are worded as behaviors versus intentions. At least in terms of relationships with variables in the existing UPB nomological network, studies that have measured UPB as intention appear to be as valid as studies measuring UPB as behavior. This also suggests future studies do not necessarily need to change UPB measures' item content (which is phrased in terms of intentions in the most popular measure) to reflect unethical pro-organizational *behavior*.

Practical Implications

The present study also has several practical implications. First, perhaps the most reliable way to decrease the likelihood of UPB in one's organization is through selection. The variables with some of the strongest relationships with UPB were personality traits and other individual differences, such as psychological entitlement, Machiavellianism, narcissism, trait moral disengagement, and low conscientiousness. Past research has shown that these traits are also associated with deviance that harms the organization (Berry et al., 2007; O'Boyle et al., 2012; Ogunfowora et al., 2021). It appears that some people are predisposed to deviant behavior (Moshagen et al., 2018). At times employers will be harmed by it, and at times they will benefit from it, at least in the short-term. Managers would be advised to screen out individuals who reflect these traits, presuming job relatedness and support from a local validity study.

Second, managers can decrease the likelihood of UPB by avoiding certain practices, such as promoting a bottom-line mentality, modeling unethical behavior by engaging in UPB oneself, and creating organizational climates where self-interests are prioritized over all other concerns.

Thus, these results primarily shed light on what behaviors managers ought to avoid, but, unfortunately, they do not offer as much in the way of what managers ought to do instead. Intuitively, ethical leadership seems like it would be a useful preventative measure, but our data suggest it has a negligible relationship. Transformational leadership also would seem like a potential candidate for reducing UPB given its moral foundation; however, we found that transformational leadership was *positively* related to UPB, not negatively. These results suggest there remains a ripe opportunity for research here to discover what leaders can do to prevent or, at least, attenuate occurrences of UPB.

Nevertheless, broadly speaking, the present study did show that employees who engage in UPB are typically more motivated by self-interest or are in environments that make self-interest more salient. A pay-for-performance (PFP) compensation system is one such environment that has been criticized for sometimes encouraging unethical, self-interested behavior (e.g., Kouchaki et al., 2013; Ordóñez et al., 2009); however, there may be ways to design PFP systems that mitigate such behavior. Employees may be more likely to engage in UPB when there is a narrow set of behavioral outcomes that are rewarded and compensation is clearly linked to those outcomes (Park & Sturman, 2021). An extreme version of this is a salesperson who is paid exclusively on commission, and his or her commission is a fixed percentage of every sale made. Under a compensation system like this, employees are motivated to engage in the rewarded behaviors to maximize the rewards associated with the behavior, even if it means ignoring other aspects of one's role that are not being rewarded (e.g., maintaining long-term customer relationships, cooperating with coworkers, abiding by organizational codes of conduct) (Greenbaum et al., 2012; Park & Sturman, 2021). To dissuade UPB, managers

should consider rewarding multiple behaviors that represent the entire job performance domain and using a variety of performance metrics.

Finally, just as important as the individual differences that do foster UPB are those which do not. Specifically, none of the demographic variables we analyzed (i.e., age, gender, job level, tenure) had *practically* significant relationships with UPB (all ρs < .10). Although prior research in some primary studies has found that having a longer tenure in an organization or achieving a higher rank leads to a greater willingness to engage in UPB (Kennedy & Anderson, 2017; Ploeger & Bisel, 2013), the cumulative meta-analytic evidence suggests this generally is not the case.

Limitations and Future Research

The first limitation was that we could only test the relationships that were available in multiple prior studies. As a result, the two nomological networks we developed are not perfectly equivalent in terms of the types of constructs represented. For example, in the nomological network for the prosocial perspective, there are two constructs related to employees' identification with a collective and one related to relationships with their supervisors, among others. On the other hand, the nomological network for the self-interest perspective has no constructs related to identity or supervisor relationships but includes four dispositional trait constructs. While the differences across nomological networks are important to acknowledge, what is most relevant to the hypotheses tested in this study is whether these differences "tip the scales"—that is, are the types of variables observed in one nomological network more likely in general to exhibit stronger relationships with work behaviors? Large-scale meta-analytic evidence suggests this is not the case. Bosco and colleagues (2015) found that the median relationship between performance (which encompasses extra-role behaviors) and work attitudes

(which includes attitudes about one's organization) is almost identical to the median relationship between performance and psychological characteristics (such as personality) (r = .17 and .16, respectively). Thus, although the nomological networks differ somewhat in the types of constructs of which they consist, these differences do not appear to make stronger relationships more likely to be observed in one network than the other. Furthermore, where constructs are more directly comparable (e.g., CWB vs. OCB), we see clear evidence of UPB relating more strongly to the self-interest perspective, which is consistent with our overall findings.

A second limitation of the present study was that we inferred, based on our underlying theory, that the reason UPB was correlated with all but one of the variables related to the self-interest perspective was because UPB was driven more strongly by self-interest. However, no study of the antecedents to UPB directly measured the extent to which UPB was motivated by self-interest relative to other motives. Thus, while our findings support this inference, we suggest that future research measure it directly and compare the extent to which the behavior is driven by various motives.

A third limitation is that there were few samples for some relationships in this meta-analysis (e.g., some relationships were based on only three samples). When a relationship was based on only a few samples, we do not view it as providing a definitive answer about the magnitude of that correlation because it is possible that relationship could change as future research provides more data. Instead, we view those relationships based on relatively few samples as addressing whether the currently available data for those relationships supports our assertion that UPB may be better understood as primarily a means of advancing one's self-interests rather than prosocial interests. We view it as useful to show that even the relationships based on small numbers of samples support this assertion, as do the relationships based on larger

numbers of samples. That the results for the large-sample and small-sample results converge on the same conclusion mitigates concerns about the usefulness or appropriateness of including constructs with few samples in this meta-analysis.

In addition to the future research directions mentioned above, we suggest four more. First, we recommend more exploration of the consequences of UPB. Some research has already begun in this vein. For instance, we already discussed the few studies that examined how people responded to others' UPB in terms of the punishment the observer would recommend (Joshi, 2016; Kundro & Nurmohamed, 2020). Recent research has also examined emotional responses (i.e., disgust and admiration) to others' UPB (Tang et al., 2021). To our knowledge, only one study examined the effects of engaging in UPB on one's own emotions (i.e., pride and guilt) and subsequent behavior (i.e., OCB) (Tang et al., 2020). We encourage research on the consequences of UPB to continue.

Second, because small *k*-sizes limited our ability to examine moderators in the present study, we recommend that future research explore moderators of the relationships between UPB and its antecedents. Several of the relationships examined in this study showed relatively wide credibility intervals, indicating that there are likely multiple sub-populations present. For example, the credibility interval for organizational commitment and UPB spanned from -.21 to .34. An interesting direction for future research would be examining the conditions under which organizational commitment is negatively related to UPB, which is counterintuitive under the prosocial perspective of UPB. It is possible that the willingness to engage in UPB varies among highly committed individuals as a function of the perceived preferences of their organizations (Wiltermuth et al., 2013)—that is, the behaviors employees anticipate will be informally or formally rewarded (Park & Sturman, 2021; L. M. Steele & Lovelace, 2023).

Third, we recommend that scholars examine more closely the behaviors that constitute UPB. In Umphress et al.'s (2010) scale, three of the six items reflect harm done to customers, two reflect harm done to the general public, and one reflects harm done to a competitor. Just as it is worth considering the varied motives for engaging in UPB, it is worth considering to whom the harm is directed. Like how the antecedents to CWB-I and CWB-O differ (Berry et al., 2007), so too may antecedents to UPB directed towards proximal stakeholders (e.g., customers, clients), distal stakeholders (e.g., general public), and competitors.

Finally, we suggest that future research investigate the role of human resource practices in UPB. We only found one such study in our review that examined a human resources construct —high-performance work systems—which was positively related to UPB (Xu & Lv, 2018). As discussed above, compensation systems (and, specifically, PFP) are quite relevant to UPB. For example, although we observed a relationship between task performance and UPB where the 95% confidence included zero, we expect that this relationship varies according to the form of PFP in one's job. To the extent that multiple behaviors are rewarded and a variety of payout formulas are used, we might expect a weaker relationship because these conditions tend to foster task performance but not UPB (Park & Sturman, 2021). In contrast, we expect a stronger relationship between UPB and task performance when few behaviors are rewarded and few, simple payout formulas are used (Park & Sturman, 2021). Taken together, the relationship between human resource practices and UPB may be a particularly fruitful area for future research to explore.

Conclusion

Some of the most notorious organizational scandals are instances of employees acting unethically on behalf of their organizations—Wells Fargo's fraudulent accounts, Volkswagen's

emissions scandal, Tesla's violation of COVID-19 lockdown orders, to name a few. To date, the way UPB has been explained is that loyal and dutiful employees take their sense of obligation to their employers too far. However, we show in this study that a stronger account of UPB is that people primarily are looking to advance their own interests, and at times, they do this in ways that also benefit their employer. We hope the theory and evidence presented here help to advance this important area of research.

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Figure 1

Flowchart Detailing the Literature Search and Screening Process

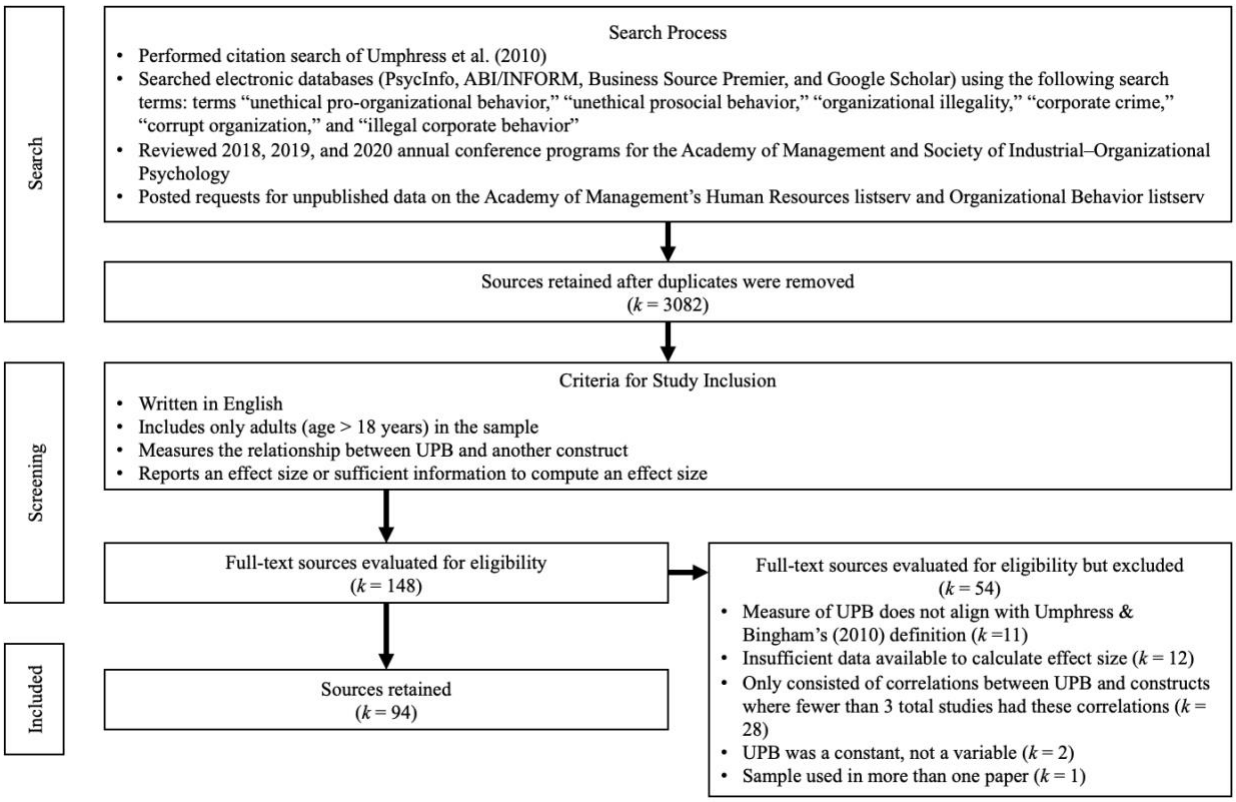


Table 1
Construct definitions and operationalizations for the hypothesized relationships

Construct	Definition	Operationalizations
UPB	"Actions that are intended to promote the effective functioning of the organization or its members (e.g., leaders) and violate core societal values, mores, laws, or standards of proper conduct" (Umphress & Bingham, 2011, p. 622)	- UPB - Unethical prosocial behavior - Unethical pro-workgroup behavior - Unethical pro-leader behavior - Crimes of obedience - Bribery - Corporate offending - Justification for helping others cheat
Prosocial Perspective		
Organizational Commitment	"An individual's psychological bond with an organization" (Choi et al., 2015, p. 1542)	- Organizational commitment - Affective organizational commitment - Workgroup commitment
Organizational Justice	"Employees' perceptions of the fairness of outcomes, procedures, and interactions" (Rupp et al., 2017, p. 940)	- Organizational justice - Interpersonal justice - Perceived overall fairness
Job Satisfaction	"The extent to which people like or dislike their jobs" (Bruck et al., 2002, p. 338)	- Job satisfaction - University satisfaction
Group Identity	"Identifying oneself as a member of, or categorizing oneself in terms of, a particular social grouping" (Ashmore et al., 2004, p. 83)	- In-group salience - Group identification - Workgroup identification

Organizational Identity	"Perception of oneness with or belongingness to" the organization (Ashforth & Mael, 1989, p. 34)	- Organizational identification - Organizational identity
Value Alignment	"The extent to which an individual's values are consistent with those of other entities" (Cheng et al., 2019, p. 36)	- Value alignment - Person–organization fit - Workplace spirituality
LMX	"The quality … of the exchange relationship that takes place between an employee and the supervisor" (Cropanzano & Mitchell, 2005, pp. 884-885)	- LMX
OCB	Tasks employees perform that go beyond their formal job role and contribute to the organization's success (Borman & Motowidlo, 1997)	- OCB - Customer-focused OCB - Organization-focused OCB
Self-Interest Perspective		
Careerism	A propensity to pursue advancing his or her career through non-performance-based means (Feldman & Weitz, 1991)	- Career self-interest - Careerism
Machiavellianism	A tendency to prioritize one's self-interests and believe that the ends justify the means (Christie & Geis, 1970)	- Machiavellianism
Narcissism	"An inflated view of self; fantasies of control, success, and admiration; and a desire to have this self-love reinforced by others" (O'Boyle et al., 2012, p. 558)	- Narcissism
Psychological Entitlement	A pervasive belief that one deserves more than others (Campbell, Bonacci, Shelton, Exline, & Bushman, 2004)	- Psychological entitlement
Self-Threat	The perception that "favorable views about oneself are … in jeopardy" (Baumeister et al., 1996, p. 8)	- Self-threat - Low self-affirmation

		- Exclusion risk
Job Insecurity	"A perceived threat to the continuity and stability of employment as it is currently experienced" (Shoss, 2017, p. 1914)	- Job insecurity
Organizational Politics	Employees' evaluation about the degree to which their work environment is characterized by self-serving behavior (Ferris et al., 2019)	- Organizational politics
CWB	Behavior that harms an organization or its stakeholders (Spector & Fox, 2005)	- CWB - CWB-O - CWB-I

Table 2
Meta-analytic estimates of the hypothesized relationships between unethical pro-organizational behavior and correlates

	k	N	$\bar{r}$	SD_r	$\bar{\rho}$	SD_ρ	95% CI_ρ	80% CV_ρ	$\%Var$
Prosocial Perspective									
Organizational Commitment (H1)	10	1945	.06	.20	.06	.21	[-.08, .21]	[-.21, .34]	12.8
Organizational Justice (H2)	7	1826	.04	.15	.05	.16	[-.08, .18]	[-.15, .25]	16.3
Job Satisfaction (H3)	11	3247	.12	.09	.13	.08	[.07, .20]	[.03, .24]	39.5
Group Identity (H4)	9	1093	.01	.11	.01	.06	[-.06, .09]	[-.07, .09]	73.3
Organizational Identity (H5)	46	11297	.16	.14	.19	.15	[.14, .24]	[-.01, .38]	18.2
Value Alignment (H6)	7	1812	.04	.13	.05	.13	[-.06, .16]	[-.12, .22]	22.8
LMX (H7)	7	1904	.12	.18	.12	.19	[-.02, .27]	[-.12, .36]	11.0
OCB (H8)	9	1854	-.06	.11	-.07	.10	[-.15, .02]	[-.20, .06]	38.4
Self-Interest Perspective									
Careerism (H9)	6	1670	.22	.07	.24	.04	[.18, .29]	[.19, .28]	74.3
Machiavellianism (H10)	8	1560	.33	.16	.41	.16	[.29, .53]	[.21, .61]	19.6
Narcissism (H11)	3	606	.31	.08	.37	.00	[.30, .45]	[.37, .37]	100.0
Psychological Entitlement (H12)	4	1049	.42	.29	.48	.30	[.18, .79]	[.09, .87]	3.4
Self-Threat (H13)	6	2149	.08	.17	.08	.19	[-.07, .24]	[-.16, .33]	9.8
Job Insecurity (H14)	3	575	.20	.06	.25	.00	[.16, .33]	[.25, .25]	100.0
Organizational Politics (H15)	3	464	.27	.07	.31	.00	[.23, .39]	[.31, .31]	100.0
CWB (H16)	13	3380	.45	.16	.53	.15	[.44, .62]	[.33, .73]	12.9

Note. k = number of independent studies; N = cumulative sample size; $\bar{r}$ = mean sample-size-weighted correlation; SD_r = mean sample-size-weighted observed standard deviation; $\bar{\rho}$ = estimated population correlation corrected for unreliability; SD_ρ = corrected standard deviation of corrected correlation; 95% CI_ρ = 95% confidence interval around corrected correlation; 80% CV_ρ = 80% credibility interval around corrected correlation; %Var = percentage of variance attributable to statistical artifacts.

Table 3
Meta-analytic estimates of the broader nomological network of unethical pro-organizational behavior

	k	N	$\bar{r}$	SD_r	$\bar{\rho}$	SD_ρ	95% CI_ρ	80% CV_ρ	%Var
Individual Antecedents									
Demographics									
Age	64	17192	-.08	.11	-.08	.10	[-.11, -.05]	[-.21, .04]	31.9
Education	23	5890	.02	.12	.03	.11	[-.03, .08]	[-.11, .17]	27.9
Gender	68	17483	-.05	.12	-.05	.10	[-.08, -.02]	[-.19, .08]	29.5
Job Level	12	2578	.07	.13	.07	.12	[.00, .15]	[-.08, .22]	28.4
Tenure	46	13544	-.03	.10	-.04	.09	[-.07, -.01]	[-.16, .08]	32.0
Dispositional Traits									
Conscientiousness	3	1251	-.38	.07	-.44	.07	[-.54, -.35]	[-.53, -.35]	34.2
Moral Courage	3	663	-.14	.11	-.20	.08	[-.33, -.06]	[-.30, -.09]	50.9
Moral Disengagement	23	4212	.44	.26	.51	.28	[.39, .63]	[.14, .87]	5.6
Moral Identity	20	5538	-.14	.19	-.17	.21	[-.27, -.07]	[-.44, .11]	9.6
Self-Control	7	2917	-.11	.16	-.13	.17	[-.26, -.00]	[-.34, .08]	10.0
Social Desirability	24	5168	-.05	.21	-.06	.24	[-.16, .04]	[-.37, .25]	10.6
Trait Emotionality									
Negative Affectivity	3	414	.12	.05	.13	.00	[.07, .20]	[.13, .13]	100.0
Positive Affectivity	3	414	.06	.12	.06	.09	[-.09, .22]	[-.06, .18]	52.1
Contextual Antecedents									
Organizational Perceptions									
Ethical Climate	11	2605	-.10	.15	-.11	.16	[-.22, -.01]	[-.32, .10]	18.1
Instrumental Climate	7	1598	.24	.07	.28	.04	[.21, .34]	[.22, .33]	73.2
Leadership									
Ethical Leadership	11	2175	.05	.12	.05	.11	[-.03, .14]	[-.09, .20]	35.6
Identification with Leader	7	1576	.21	.14	.25	.15	[.12, .37]	[.06, .43]	21.0
Supervisor Bottom-Line Mentality	6	1075	.26	.16	.29	.14	[.16, .41]	[.10, .47]	21.9
Supervisor UPB	5	1203	.24	.06	.27	.00	[.22, .32]	[.27, .27]	100.0
Transformational Leadership	6	1380	.16	.07	.18	.04	[.11, .25]	[.13, .23]	76.6
Correlates									
General Ethical Behavior	3	298	.20	.30	.20	.29	[-.15, .54]	[-.17, .57]	10.3
Task Performance	5	1221	-.17	.25	-.19	.26	[-.43, .04]	[-.52, .13]	6.4
Consequences									
Recommended Punishment	4	1317	-.14	.10	-.15	.08	[-.24, -.05]	[-.25, -.04]	30.4

Note. k = number of independent studies; N = cumulative sample size; $\bar{r}$ = mean sample-size-weighted correlation; SD_r = mean sample-size-weighted observed standard deviation; $\bar{\rho}$ = estimated population correlation corrected for unreliability; SD_ρ = corrected standard deviation of corrected correlation; 95% CI_ρ = 95% confidence interval around corrected correlation; 80% CV_ρ

= 80% credibility interval around corrected correlation; %Var = percentage of variance attributable to statistical artifacts. Gender was coded as 0 = males, 1 = females.

Table 4
Categorical moderator analyses comparing when unethical pro-organizational behavior is measured as intention or behavior

	k	N	$\bar{r}$	SD_r	$\bar{\rho}$	SD_ρ	95% CI_ρ	80% CV_ρ	$\%Var$	Mod. Test
Age										$t_{(62)}$ = .34
Intention	52	14716	-.08	.11	-.08	.10	[-.12, -.05]	[-.21, .04]	30.7	
Behavior	12	2476	-.07	.11	-.07	.09	[-.14, .00]	[-.19, .05]	39.2	
Careerism										*Not calculable*
Intention	4	1262	.25	.04	.27	.00	[.23, .31]	[.27, .27]	100.0	
Behavior	2	408	.12	.03	.13	.00	[.09, .18]	[.13, .13]	100.0	
CWB										$t_{(11)}$ = 1.09
Intention	10	2207	.41	.16	.50	.18	[.38, .62]	[.27, .73]	12.6	
Behavior	3	1173	.52	.11	.58	.08	[.48, .69]	[.47, .69]	19.4	
Education										$t_{(21)}$ = .90
Intention	19	4773	.01	.11	.01	.09	[-.04, .06]	[-.11, .13]	35.6	
Behavior	4	1117	.08	.15	.08	.15	[-.07, .24]	[-.10, .27]	15.8	
Ethical Climate										$t_{(9)}$ = 3.75*
Intention	9	2272	-.08	.15	-.09	.16	[-.21, .02]	[-.30, .12]	17.1	
Behavior	2	333	-.22	.05	-.29	.00	[-.37, -.21]	[-.29, -.29]	100.0	
Ethical Leadership										$t_{(9)}$ = 7.33*
Intention	9	1961	.07	.10	.08	.09	[.00, .16]	[-.04, .20]	42.0	
Behavior	2	214	-.13	.07	-.14	.00	[-.23, -.05]	[-.14, -.14]	100.0	
Gender										$t_{(66)}$ = .37
Intention	55	14869	-.05	.12	-.05	.11	[-.09, -.02]	[-.19, .09]	27.2	
Behavior	13	2614	-.04	.10	-.04	.08	[-.10, .02]	[-.14, .06]	47.2	
Job Satisfaction										$t_{(9)}$ = .79
Intention	9	2857	.13	.08	.14	.06	[.09, .20]	[.07, .22]	50.9	
Behavior	2	390	.05	.14	.06	.14	[-.17, .29]	[-.13, .24]	24.9	
Identification with Leader										$t_{(5)}$ = 2.03
Intention	4	832	.13	.10	.15	.11	[.01, .28]	[.01, .29]	39.5	

Behavior	3	744	.30	.13	.33	.12	[.17, .48]	[.17, .49]	21.3	
LMX										$t_{(5)} = 2.42$
Intention	4	1232	.19	.18	.21	.19	[.01, .41]	[-.04, .45]	9.1	
Behavior	3	672	-.02	.06	-.02	.00	[-.09, .05]	[-.02, -.02]	100.0	
Moral Disengagement										$t_{(21)} = 2.46$*
Intention	17	3189	.49	.26	.57	.29	[.43, .71]	[.20, .93]	4.9	
Behavior	6	1023	.28	.17	.32	.18	[.16, .48]	[.09, .55]	16.7	
Moral Identity										$t_{(18)} = .50$
Intention	11	3977	-.13	.22	-.16	.25	[-.31, .00]	[-.47, .16]	5.8	
Behavior	9	1561	-.18	.09	-.20	.08	[-.27, -.12]	[-.30, -.09]	52.4	
OCB										$t_{(7)} = 1.56$
Intention	6	1365	-.03	.08	-.03	.05	[-.11, .04]	[-.09, .03]	71.1	
Behavior	3	489	-.14	.15	-.16	.14	[-.34, .03]	[-.33, .02]	27.7	
Organizational Commitment										$t_{(8)} = .28$
Intention	6	1509	.06	.22	.07	.24	[-.13, .27]	[-.24, .38]	8.3	
Behavior	4	436	.04	.12	.04	.08	[-.08, .17]	[-.05, .14]	65.2	
Organizational Identity										$t_{(44)} = 1.49$
Intention	36	9519	.17	.14	.20	.15	[.15, .26]	[.01, .39]	17.6	
Behavior	10	1778	.10	.15	.12	.15	[.01, .20]	[-.07, .31]	25.1	
Self-Control										$t_{(5)} = 4.79$*
Intention	3	1669	.00	.08	.00	.07	[-.10, .11]	[-.09, .10]	31.2	
Behavior	4	1248	-.26	.09	-.29	.09	[-.39, -.18]	[-.41, -.17]	29.0	
Self-Threat										$t_{(4)} = 1.70$
Intention	4	1873	.06	.17	.06	.20	[-.14, .26]	[-.19, .31]	7.4	
Behavior	2	276	.21	.05	.23	.00	[.18, .29]	[.23, .23]	100.0	
Social Desirability										$t_{(22)} = .11$
Intention	18	3974	-.05	.23	-.06	.27	[-.19, .07]	[-.40, .28]	8.9	
Behavior	6	1194	-.05	.15	-.05	.15	[-.19, .08]	[-.25, .14]	23.1	
Supervisor Bottom-Line Mentality										$t_{(4)} = .68$

Intention	3	479	.21	.17	.24	.17	[.02, .45]	[.02, .45]	20.5	
Behavior	3	596	.30	.14	.32	.11	[.17, .47]	[.18, .46]	28.0	
Supervisor UPB										*Not calculable*
Intention	2	599	.19	.03	.23	.00	[.16, .29]	[.23, .23]	100.0	
Behavior	3	604	.28	.05	.30	.00	[.25, .35]	[.30, .30]	100.0	
Task Performance										$t_{(3)} = 2.12$
Intention	2	529	.02	.15	.01	.15	[-.21, .24]	[-.18, .20]	17.9	
Behavior	3	692	-.32	.21	-.34	.22	[-.59, -.08]	[-.61, -.06]	7.8	
Tenure										$t_{(44)} = 1.92$
Intention	41	12306	-.04	.11	-.04	.10	[-.08, .00]	[-.17, .09]	29.0	
Behavior	5	1238	-.01	.04	-.01	.00	[-.05, .02]	[-.01, -.01]	100.0	

Note. * $p < .05$. k = number of independent studies; N = cumulative sample size; $\bar{r}$ = mean sample-size-weighted correlation; SD_r = mean sample-size-weighted observed standard deviation; $\bar{\rho}$ = estimated population correlation corrected for unreliability; SD_ρ = corrected standard deviation of corrected correlation; 95% CI_ρ = 95% confidence interval around corrected correlation; 80% CV_ρ = 80% credibility interval around corrected correlation; %Var = percentage of variance attributable to statistical artifacts; Mod. Test = moderator test using a *t*-test (with $df = k_1 - k_2$) of the significance of the difference between the intention versus behavior corrected correlations; "Not calculable" means the *t*-statistic could not be calculated because $SD_\rho = 0$ for both the intention and behavior correlations, which causes the denominator of the *t*-statistic to be zero. In this case, although the *t*-statistic could not be calculated, the two correlations do differ significantly because the correlations differ and there is no residual variance around those correlations (i.e., $SD_\rho = 0$). Gender was coded as 0 = males, 1 = females.

Appendix

Prior to analyzing our data, we assigned ten constructs to represent the self-interest perspective and eight to represent the prosocial perspective (see second column in Table A1). These assignments were made based on our understanding of the theory and evidence relevant to each construct. Before submitting this paper to *Journal of Applied Psychology*, we received friendly reviews and were advised to find a more systematic approach to assigning constructs to represent the self-interest and prosocial perspectives. To make these construct assignments in a systematic, transparent, and reproducible way, we decided to collect ratings from subject matter experts. We describe the ratings data collection next.

We collected ratings from ten OB/HR faculty and one doctoral student, none of whom were involved in the present research. We created an online survey, which consisted of the name and definition of each construct included in the present meta-analysis (except for constructs with no clear link to either of our nomological networks [e.g., demographics]), along with the following item: "Employees who are high in [construct X] are more likely to be motivated to act in ways that are…" Participants then provided ratings on a 7-point semantic differential item, where 1 = "primarily self-interested and to benefit themselves," and 7 = "primarily prosocial and to benefit others (e.g., coworkers, their employer)." The wording of the stem and anchors slightly varied across constructs to align with the meaning of the construct. For example, the stem of the organizational commitment rating was as follows: "Having a stronger organizational commitment will motivate employees to act in ways that are …" The full results of this ratings task are provided in Table A1. We selected eight constructs with the highest ratings to represent the prosocial perspective and eight constructs with the lowest ratings to represent the self-interest perspective. These 16 constructs are reflected in our hypotheses.

After collecting the construct ratings, we made two "judgment calls" in selecting which constructs to include in our hypotheses. The first was about the number of constructs to include. We selected eight for each perspective to balance comprehensiveness and considerations of manuscript length, but one could certainly argue for including more or fewer. Thus, we conducted a sensitivity analysis (which we refer to as Sensitivity Analysis 1) in which we expanded the number of constructs that could be included in each nomological network. For Sensitivity Analysis 1, we included all constructs that received a rating significantly different from the midpoint of a 7-point scale (i.e., 4). Constructs that were rated significantly higher than the midpoint were included in the prosocial perspective, and constructs that were rated significantly lower than the midpoint were included in the self-interest perspective.

The results of Sensitivity Analysis 1 are shown in Table A2. In the prosocial perspective, the trend is consistent with the hypothesized relationships, with most meta-analytic correlations being small positive relationships and, several of these relationships have 95% confidence intervals that include zero. Similarly, in the self-interest perspective, the trend is consistent with the hypothesized relationships, with all but one construct (i.e., self-control) exhibiting small to moderate positive correlations with UPB where the 95% confidence interval does not include zero.

The second judgment call we made was excluding constructs focused on morality (i.e., ethical climate, ethical leadership, instrumental climate, moral courage, moral disengagement, moral identity, transformational leadership, and supervisor bottom-line mentality). We did this because these constructs cannot distinguish between the two perspectives on UPB motives that we examined (i.e., prosocial vs. self-interest). That is, a correlation between UPB and any of the aforementioned constructs would not clearly support either the prosocial or self-interest

perspectives. For this reason, we excluded these constructs from our hypotheses. However, for the second sensitivity analysis (i.e., Sensitivity Analysis 2), we explored what the results would have been if we had included the morally focused constructs. Using the data we collected from OB/HR faculty and an OB/HR doctoral student, we simply took the eight constructs with the highest ratings to represent the prosocial perspective and eight constructs with the lowest ratings to represent the self-interest perspective, regardless of the relevance of each construct to morality.

The results of Sensitivity Analysis 2 are shown in Table A3. In the prosocial perspective, five of the constructs were already included in our hypotheses. The three new constructs (i.e., ethical leadership, moral identity, and ethical climate) exhibit either a relationship where the 95% confidence interval includes zero or a weak negative relationship with UPB. Because we would have hypothesized positive relationships between these constructs and UPB, none of the hypotheses would have been supported. This is consistent with the broader trend in the results for the prosocial perspective reported in the main body of the manuscript. In the self-interest perspective, only one construct differs from the constructs included in our hypotheses—moral disengagement replaces careerism. Moral disengagement has a positive relationship ($\rho = .51$, 95% *CI* = [.39, .63]) with UPB, which would have supported the hypothesis. This result is again consistent with the broader trend in the results for the self-interest perspective reported in the main body of the manuscript.

Table A1

Ratings of constructs' associations with prosocial or self-interested motives and assignments of constructs to prosocial and self-interest perspectives

Construct	Initially Assigned to Which Perspective?	Final Assignment After Collecting Construct Ratings	*M*	*SD*	Sig.
Machiavellianism	Self-Interest	Self-Interest	1.25	0.45	**
Psychological Entitlement	Self-Interest	Self-Interest	1.25	0.45	**
Narcissism	–	Self-Interest	1.30	0.48	**
Moral Disengagement	Self-Interest	–	1.33	0.49	**
Self-Threat	Self-Interest	Self-Interest	1.75	0.62	**
Organizational Politics	Self-Interest	Self-Interest	1.75	0.97	**
CWB	Self-Interest	Self-Interest	1.83	1.03	**
Job Insecurity	Self-Interest	Self-Interest	2.00	1.04	**
Supervisor Bottom-Line Mentality	Self-Interest	–	2.08	0.79	**
Careerism	Self-Interest	Self-Interest	2.42	1.08	**
Instrumental Climate	–	–	4.00	0.67	
Supervisor UPB	–	–	4.10	1.79	
Conscientiousness	Prosocial	–	4.17	1.19	
Self-Control	–	–	4.50	0.71	†
General Ethical Behavior	–	–	4.50	0.97	
Identification with Leader	Prosocial	–	4.75	1.60	†
Job Satisfaction	Prosocial	Prosocial	4.80	1.19	*
LMX	Prosocial	Prosocial	5.08	1.24	*
Moral Courage	–	–	5.10	1.29	*
Transformational Leadership	–	–	5.10	0.99	**
Organizational Justice	Prosocial	Prosocial	5.33	0.65	**
Ethical Climate	–	–	5.40	0.97	**
Moral Identity	Self-Interest	–	5.42	1.24	**
OCB	Prosocial	Prosocial	5.58	1.31	**
Ethical Leadership	–	–	5.70	0.82	**
Organizational Commitment	Prosocial	Prosocial	5.92	0.67	**
Value Alignment	–	Prosocial	6.00	0.67	**
Organizational Identity	Prosocial	Prosocial	6.08	0.79	**
Group Identity	–	Prosocial	6.10	1.10	**

Note. Constructs are ordered from lowest to highest mean rating. The ratings were provided on a 7-point semantic differential item, where 1 = "primarily self-interested and to benefit themselves," and 7 = "primarily prosocial and to benefit others (e.g., coworkers, their

employer).” Statistical significance was determined by a single-sample *t*-tests where 4 (i.e., the mid-point of the scale) was treated as the comparison mean.
$^{**}p < .01$, $^{*}p < .05$, $^{\dagger}p < .10$.

Table A2

Sensitivity analysis 1: Meta-analytic estimates of the relationships between unethical pro-organizational behavior and all constructs rated significantly higher or lower than the midpoint in the construct ratings survey

	Construct Rating	k	N	$\bar{r}$	SD_r	$\bar{\rho}$	SD_ρ	95% CI_ρ	80% CV_ρ
Prosocial Model									
Group Identity	6.10**	9	1093	.01	.11	.01	.06	[-.06, .09]	[-.07, .09]
Organizational Identity	6.08**	46	11297	.16	.14	.19	.15	[.14, .24]	[-.01, .38]
Value Alignment	6.00**	7	1812	.04	.13	.05	.13	[-.06, .16]	[-.12, .22]
Organizational Commitment	5.92**	10	1945	.06	.20	.06	.21	[-.08, .21]	[-.21, .34]
Ethical Leadership	5.70**	11	2175	.05	.12	.05	.11	[-.03, .14]	[-.09, .20]
OCB	5.58**	9	1854	-.06	.11	-.07	.10	[-.15, .02]	[-.20, .06]
Moral Identity	5.42**	20	5538	-.14	.19	-.17	.21	[-.27, -.07]	[-.44, .11]
Ethical Climate	5.40**	11	2605	-.10	.15	-.11	.16	[-.22, -.01]	[-.32, .10]
Organizational Justice	5.33**	7	1826	.04	.15	.05	.16	[-.08, .18]	[-.15, .25]
Moral Courage	5.10*	3	663	-.14	.11	-.20	.08	[-.33, -.06]	[-.30, -.09]
Transformational Leadership	5.10**	6	1380	.16	.07	.18	.04	[.11, .25]	[.13, .23]
LMX	5.08*	7	1904	.12	.18	.12	.19	[-.02, .27]	[-.12, .36]
Job Satisfaction	4.80*	11	3247	.12	.09	.13	.08	[.07, .20]	[.03, .24]
Self-Interest Model									
Machiavellianism	1.25**	8	1560	.33	.16	.41	.16	[.29, .53]	[.21, .61]
Psychological Entitlement	1.25**	4	1049	.42	.29	.48	.30	[.18, .79]	[.09, .87]
Narcissism	1.30**	3	606	.31	.08	.37	.00	[.30, .45]	[.37, .37]
Moral Disengagement	1.33**	23	4212	.44	.26	.51	.28	[.39, .63]	[.14, .87]
Self-Threat	1.75**	6	2149	.08	.17	.08	.19	[-.07, .24]	[-.16, .33]
Organizational Politics	1.75**	3	464	.27	.07	.31	.00	[.23, .39]	[.31, .31]
CWB	1.83**	13	3380	.45	.16	.53	.15	[.44, .62]	[.33, .73]
Job Insecurity	2.00**	3	575	.20	.06	.25	.00	[.16, .33]	[.25, .25]
Supervisor Bottom-Line Mentality	2.08**	6	1075	.26	.16	.29	.14	[.16, .41]	[.10, .47]

Careerism	2.42**	6	1670	.22	.07	.24	.04	[.18, .29]	[.19, .28]

Note. Construct Rating = mean rating and result of single-sample *t*-tests where 4 (i.e., the mid-point of the scale) was treated as the comparison mean and low and high scores represented a stronger association with self-interest and prosocial motives, respectively; k = number of independent studies; N = cumulative sample size; $\bar{r}$ = mean sample-size-weighted correlation; SD_r = mean sample-size-weighted observed standard deviation; $\bar{\rho}$ = estimated population correlation corrected for unreliability; SD_ρ = corrected standard deviation of corrected correlation; 95% CI_ρ = 95% confidence interval around corrected correlation; 80% CV_ρ = 80% credibility interval around corrected correlation.

$^{**}p < .01$, $^{*}p < .05$.

Table A3

Sensitivity analysis 2: Meta-analytic estimates of the relationships between unethical pro-organizational behavior and the highest and lowest rated constructs (including morally focused constructs)

	Construct Rating	k	N	$\bar{r}$	SD_r	$\bar{\rho}$	SD_ρ	95% CI_ρ	80% CV_ρ
Prosocial Model									
Group Identity	6.10**	9	1093	.01	.11	.01	.06	[-.06, .09]	[-.07, .09]
Organizational Identity	6.08**	46	11297	.16	.14	.19	.15	[.14, .24]	[-.01, .38]
Value Alignment	6.00**	7	1812	.04	.13	.05	.13	[-.06, .16]	[-.12, .22]
Organizational Commitment	5.92**	10	1945	.06	.20	.06	.21	[-.08, .21]	[-.21, .34]
Ethical Leadership	5.70**	11	2175	.05	.12	.05	.11	[-.03, .14]	[-.09, .20]
OCB	5.58**	9	1854	-.06	.11	-.07	.10	[-.15, .02]	[-.20, .06]
Moral Identity	5.42**	20	5538	-.14	.19	-.17	.21	[-.27, -.07]	[-.44, .11]
Ethical Climate	5.40**	11	2605	-.10	.15	-.11	.16	[-.22, -.01]	[-.32, .10]
Self-Interest Model									
Machiavellianism	1.25**	8	1560	.33	.16	.41	.16	[.29, .53]	[.21, .61]
Psychological Entitlement	1.25**	4	1049	.42	.29	.48	.30	[.18, .79]	[.09, .87]
Narcissism	1.30**	3	606	.31	.08	.37	.00	[.30, .45]	[.37, .37]
Moral Disengagement	1.33**	23	4212	.44	.26	.51	.28	[.39, .63]	[.14, .87]
Self-Threat	1.75**	6	2149	.08	.17	.08	.19	[-.07, .24]	[-.16, .33]
Organizational Politics	1.75**	3	464	.27	.07	.31	.00	[.23, .39]	[.31, .31]
CWB	1.83**	13	3380	.45	.16	.53	.15	[.44, .62]	[.33, .73]
Job Insecurity	2.00**	3	575	.20	.06	.25	.00	[.16, .33]	[.25, .25]

Note. Construct Rating = mean rating and result of single-sample *t*-tests where 4 (i.e., the mid-point of the scale) was treated as the comparison mean and low and high scores represented a stronger association with self-interest and prosocial motives, respectively; k = number of independent studies; N = cumulative sample size; $\bar{r}$ = mean sample-size-weighted correlation; SD_r = mean sample-size-weighted observed standard deviation; $\bar{\rho}$ = estimated population correlation corrected for unreliability; SD_ρ = corrected standard deviation of corrected correlation; 95% CI_ρ = 95% confidence interval around corrected correlation; 80% CV_ρ = 80% credibility interval around corrected correlation.

**$p < .01$.

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